

Fake Trap

Three traps lived in the answer. Four lived in you. This last one comes from everywhere else: other people’s AI, pointed at what you see.

AI now makes fake text cheap. Fake images cheap. Fake voices cheap. And fake video passes now, especially in short clips, bad lighting, or anything you scroll past in three seconds. The price of generating something convincing has collapsed, and it’s only going one direction.

One more tell comes before any check: your own reaction. The fakes that travel are built to spike you: outrage, fear, thrill, hope. Strong feeling is the cue to slow down. And this isn’t only an AI skill: a doctored screenshot or an out-of-context photo beats your eyes the same way. The checks below catch all of them.

School closed tomorrow, says a post going around tonight.

 **The old test: does it look real?**

Logo checks out. Wording sounds official. The comments are reacting like it’s true. Verdict: real.

WHAT HAPPENED

- Read the pixels
- Read the vibes
- Both are easy to fake

 **The new test: where did it come from?**

The account was made last week. Nothing on the school website, nothing from the district, nothing in local news. Verdict: unverified.

WHAT HAPPENED

- Read the trail
- Checked who would actually know
- The trail is hard to fake

Same post. Two tests. Opposite answers. The old test reads the image, and images can now be rendered to order. **Fake Trap is believing it because it looks real.**

Looking real used to be evidence. Now it’s a setting. So the test moves off the image and onto the trail: three checks.

THE THREE CHECKS

Run any image, clip, voicemail, or screenshot through these before you react, share, or believe.

CHECK 1 · SOURCE

Where did this come from?

Did this come from somewhere with a reason to know? A direct news source. A person you actually know. A verified account. Or did it come from ‘a friend forwarded it,’ which is the digital version of ‘I heard from a guy.’

CHECK 2 · CONTEXT

Does the surrounding info hold up?

Look around the thing, not just at it. Date, location, what else was happening. A clip of your principal saying something wild on Tuesday afternoon: was your principal even in that meeting on Tuesday? Does the room match where they actually were?

CHECK 3 · CORROBORATION

Does anywhere else show the same thing?

The biggest filter. Real news shows up in multiple places. Real events get talked about by people who weren’t coordinating. If a clip is everywhere on TikTok but nowhere on Google News, that’s information.

THE DETECTOR DEAD END

Once your eyes stop working, the next move most people reach for is a detector. Don’t lean on it. A detector is one more AI making one more prediction, and the fakes it chases improve faster than it does. Treat its verdict as a clue, never a ruling. The real checks don’t look at the image at all.

 **Verify somewhere the sender doesn’t control.** A voicemail asks for something urgent: call back on the number you already have. A clip is blowing up: look for it on a channel the poster doesn’t run. Until a second, independent source shows the same thing, ‘unverified’ is your answer. Your eyes still work fine for reading, judging, and enjoying what you know is made up. They just stopped working as a lie detector.

Seeing isn’t proof anymore.

Ask where it came from before you believe it.

 **WHEN YOU’RE THE TARGET**

If a fake is about you: a photo, a clip, an account with your name, don’t handle it alone, and don’t delete the evidence.

Screenshot everything, note where you saw it, and bring an adult in that day: a parent, a counselor, someone at school. Platforms take impersonation and fake images of minors seriously, and takedown goes faster with documentation. You did nothing wrong by being targeted.